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What Might Change for Dad in the Next Few Years?

A worksheet for writing down what your family expects, each change beside a question to ask.

Dad has mentioned selling the lake cabin someday. He's talked about moving nearer to your sister. These are ordinary family plans, and they're worth having on paper, because they're also the kind of change worth asking a professional about before anyone acts.

Under each heading, write what your family expects or what Dad has mentioned, with a rough date if there is one, and one question beside it. A guess is fine, and no amounts are needed.

If nothing comes to mind, write “nothing we know of” and move on. Fill it in with Dad if he's willing. They're his plans.

Income

Anything that may change what comes in: work that stops, a pension or other payment that starts or ends, rent from a property.

FOR EXAMPLE Dad means to give up the part-time bookkeeping next year. Question: who, if anyone, would want to know about a change in his income?

Savings and property

Accounts that may be opened, closed or combined, and anything he owns that may be sold, bought or passed on. Just what, and roughly when.

FOR EXAMPLE He's talked about selling the lake cabin someday. No date. Question: what should we ask, and whom, before it's listed?

Where he lives

A move, a smaller place, someone moving in with him, or Dad moving in with one of you.

FOR EXAMPLE He's mentioned moving nearer to Karen, maybe in a couple of years. Question: what would a professional want to know before a move?

Care

Any help he has now, and what he has said he'd want if he ever needed more. Write what he said, not what you expect.

FOR EXAMPLE No help now. He's said he'd want to stay in his own house as long as he can. Question: who would we talk to first if that changed?

Family and other circumstances

A marriage, a change in who lives with or depends on whom, or anything else that doesn't fit above.

FOR EXAMPLE Dad and Eileen have talked about getting married. Question: what should they ask, and whom, beforehand?

Who filled this in, on what date, and when you'll look at it again

What this shows you

Two things: the changes your family can see coming, and a question to go with each one. It doesn't show whether any of them matters for Medicaid, whether it would ever have to be reported, or what Dad should do about it. Those answers depend on his state and his situation, so the questions go to your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney or a licensed financial professional before anyone acts. Nothing here adds up to a score or a level, and nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've written down what may be coming for Dad instead of carrying it in your head, each change beside a question. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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